

**Econ 201 - 01 – Intermediate Microeconomic Analysis
Spring 2026
Wellesley College**

This syllabus describes the expectations and requirements for this class, which are aligned with the economics department's guidelines found here:

<https://intranet.wellesley.edu/academics/departments/economics/principles-and-guidelines>.

Ama Baafrā Abeberese

781-283-2940, aabeberese@wellesley.edu

Office Hours:

Office Hours Zoom Meeting ID [95829243775](#) (Passcode:econ)

Office hours will be as follows or by appointment.

Wednesdays, 11am to 12pm, 1:30pm to 2:30pm (*via Zoom or in-person (PNE 412)*)

Thursdays, 3:30pm to 5pm (*via Zoom*)

Course Description: This course builds upon the concepts studied in Principles of Microeconomics. We will use a conceptual framework and analytical tools to understand the behavior and decision-making of individual economic agents (consumers, producers) and the implications for market outcomes and welfare.

Course Prerequisites: The following are strict prerequisites for this course: Econ 101/101P and Econ 102/102P and one math course taken at Wellesley at the level of Math 115/115P or higher. If you have not taken these courses, you may not take Econ 201.

Course Meetings: This course meets on Tuesdays and Fridays from 11:20am to 12:35pm, and on Wednesdays from 12:30pm to 1:20pm, in Pendleton East 139. There will be no class on the following dates: February 4, February 17 (Monday schedule), March 11, March 17, 18, 20 (Spring break), April 8, April 15 (Ruhlman conference), and April 22. Some of the Wednesday classes will be used for extra office hours (please see the schedule below).

Textbook: The textbook is *Microeconomics* by Professors Skeath and Velenchik (henceforth, S&V), which they have graciously shared with us. The textbook is posted on the course's Brightspace website. ***Please do not share or distribute the textbook.***

Readings: You are required to do the readings from the textbook as well as the articles and other sources in the course outline below before class. Links to some sources are provided in the syllabus. All other sources are posted in the readings folder on the course's Brightspace website. The material from these sources will appear on problem sets and exams. Please come to class prepared to answer questions on these sources.

Evaluation:

Your grade for the class will be based on problem sets and three exams as follows.

Problem sets (15%): There will be 7 problem sets. The due dates for the problem sets are listed in the course outline below. Problem sets should be turned in by the beginning of class on the due date. ***Problem sets should be submitted electronically via Brightspace. Do not email problem sets.*** Please see page 10 for [Brightspace instructions for submitting problem sets](#). Please note that problem sets should be turned in on time to allow me to provide solutions to the class once problem sets are submitted. For each day that a problem set is late, 20% of the grade will be deducted. For instance, if a problem set due on a Friday is submitted the following day, on Saturday, the highest possible score will be 80%. I will drop your lowest problem set score.

Midterm exams: There will be 2 timed, open-book, ***in-person*** midterm exams. It is an open-book exam in the sense that hardcopy (paper) materials are allowed, but ***no electronic devices are allowed***. Electronic devices not allowed include, but are not limited to, laptops, tablets, cell phones, smartwatches and calculators. I will provide you with calculators for the midterm exams. The midterm exam with your highest score will account for 30% of your grade and the midterm exam with your lowest score will account for 20% of your grade.

Midterm exam 1 will be held on ***Tuesday, March 3***, during class time.

Midterm exam 2 will be held on ***Tuesday, April 14***, during class time.

Please also note that there will be no make-up exam dates, and missed exams will receive a zero except in the event of a documented emergency that prevents you from attending class. If, unfortunately, there is such an event, please contact both your class dean and me and provide documentation of the emergency. You will then be able to reschedule your midterm, but the midterm will have to be completed before class on Friday that week, otherwise your other exams will be reweighted to account for the missed midterm.

Final exam (35%): The final exam will be timed, open-book and ***in-person***, and will be cumulative. You can use your own calculator. It is an open-book exam in the sense that hardcopy (paper) materials are allowed, but ***no electronic devices, other than your calculator, are allowed***. The final exam will be available during finals period, from ***9am on Tuesday, May 5, till 4pm on Friday, May 8***, in the locations and during the two-and-a-half hour exam sessions designated by the Registrar's office.

Please note that there is no virtual option for the exams.

Class participation: You are required to attend each class on time and actively participate. After two absences, your final score for the class will be reduced by one percentage point for each additional absence except in the event of emergencies. If, unfortunately, there is such an event, please contact both your class dean and me.

Course Tutor: The tutor for this course is Kriti Sarav. She will be available to provide help during weekly office hours from 7pm to 9pm on Thursdays in PNE 127.

Course Website: The problem sets, other material and announcements will be posted on the course's Brightspace website at <https://brightspace.wellesley.edu/d2l/home/12847>. ***Please do NOT turn off announcement notifications for the course on Brightspace, otherwise you will miss important announcements.***

Accessibility and Disability Resources: If you have a disability or condition and need any academic accommodations, please contact Accessibility and Disability Resources (<https://intranet.wellesley.edu/administrative/accessibility-and-disability-resources>) at accessibility@wellesley.edu or 781-283-1300.

Email: I will usually respond to emails sent on weekdays within 24 hours. For emails sent during the weekend, the response time may be longer so please plan accordingly.

Proprietary Course Material: All the materials in this course are the intellectual property of the instructor and are meant for the students currently in the course this semester. Please do not share the materials with anyone. Please do not consult materials from previous versions of the course.

Honor Code: Please note that, in taking this class, you are committing to abide by the College's Honor Code to "act with honesty, integrity, and respect". Please see <https://www.wellesley.edu/studentlife/aboutus/honor> for more information.

Any work you submit for this course should be generated by you, either individually or, in the case of an assignment submitted as a group, with your group members. Having another person or entity do any portion of your work or submitting work generated by AI tools, e.g. ChatGPT, as your own will be considered a violation of the Honor Code.

Other:

The speaker for this year's economics department's Calderwood Lecture is Professor Miguel Urquiola from Columbia University. The talk will be at 4:15pm in Tishman on April 7. The department will send out more information prior to the talk.

Tentative Course Outline: On the next page is a tentative course outline. Please note that the dates for covering specific material and readings may change depending on our pace during the semester. If there are any significant changes, this syllabus will be updated on the course's Brightspace website and you will receive a notification. The "Important Dates" in the table below will not change.

Important Dates	
January 30	Problem set 1 due
February 13	Problem set 2 due
February 20	Problem set 3 due
March 3	Midterm exam 1 in class
March 13	Problem set 4 due
March 27	Problem set 5 due
April 3	Problem set 6 due
April 14	Midterm exam 2 in class
April 24	Problem set 7 due
May 5 to 8	Final exam period

Tentative Course Outline:

Week		Topics	Required Reading
1	Jan 20	Introduction	S&V, Chapter 1
	Consumer Theory		
	Jan 21	Utility and Preferences	- S&V, Chapter 2, Sections 1 to 3A “What Pumpkin Spice Lattes Can Teach Us About Economics.” <i>CNBC</i>, September 25, 2022.
	Jan 23	Utility and Preferences	S&V, Chapter 2, Sections 3B to 3D, 4 to 5
2	Jan 27	Constraints and Choice	S&V, Chapter 3, Section 1
	Jan 28	Constraints and Choice	S&V, Chapter 3, Section 2
	Jan 30	Jan 30: Problem set 1 due Constraints and Choice (Lagrange Approach) Mathematical Techniques for Econ 201	- S&V, Chapter 3, Section 3; Chapter 4, pages 6 to 9 (Lagrange Method) - Derivatives (https://www.mathsisfun.com/calculus/)
3	Feb 3	Demand Functions and Comparative Statics	S&V, Chapter 3, Sections 4 to 5; Chapter 4, Sections 1 to 2
	Feb 4	No class (Extra office hours on Zoom)	
	Feb 6	Demand Functions and Comparative Statics	- S&V, Chapter 4, Sections 3 to 5 “Why Are C.E.O.s Suddenly Obsessed With ‘Elasticity’?” <i>New York Times</i>, August 19, 2022. “Dunkin’s “Shrinkflation Gate” Shows Price Elasticity Has Its Limits.” <i>Coffee Intelligence</i>, November 28, 2025.

Week		Topics	Required Reading
4	Feb 10	Applications (Labor Supply)	S&V, Chapter 5, Sections 1 to 4
	Feb 11	Applications (Intertemporal Choice)	S&V, Chapter 5, Sections 5A to 5B
	Feb 13	<i>Feb 13: Problem set 2 due</i> Applications (Intertemporal Choice)	S&V, Chapter 5, Sections 5C to 6
5	Feb 17	<i>No class (Monday schedule)</i>	
	Feb 18	Risk and Insurance	S&V, Chapter 6
	Feb 20	<i>Feb 20: Problem set 3 due</i> Risk and Insurance	Besanko and Braeutigam, 4th Edition, Pages 623 to 627
6	Producer Theory		
	Feb 24	Production Functions	- S&V, Chapter 7 “Does It Pay for Companies to Do Good?” <i>NPR</i>, September 17, 2019
	Feb 25	Cost Functions	S&V, Chapter 8, Sections 1 and 2
	Feb 27	Review for midterm exam 1	

Week		Topics	Required Reading
7	Mar 3	<i>Mar 3: Midterm exam 1 in class</i>	
	Mar 4	Cost Functions	S&V, Chapter 8, Section 3
	Mar 6	Short-Run Profit Maximization and Supply	S&V, Chapter 9, Sections 1 to 5
8	Mar 10	Long-run Profit Maximization and Supply	S&V, Chapter 9, Sections 6A to 6C
	Mar 11	<i>No class (Extra office hours on Zoom)</i>	
	Mar 13	<i>Mar 13: Problem set 4 due</i> Long-run Profit Maximization and Supply	S&V, Chapter 9, Section 6D
9	Mar 17, 18, 20	<i>No classes (Spring break)</i>	

Week	Topics		Required Reading
10	Analysis of the Competitive Market Equilibrium		
	Mar 24	Competitive (Partial) Equilibrium	S&V, Chapter 10, Sections 1 and 2
	Mar 25	Competitive (Partial) Equilibrium	S&V, Chapter 10, Section 3
	Mar 27	Mar 27: Problem set 5 due General Equilibrium	S&V, Chapter 11, Section 1
11	Mar 31	General Equilibrium	S&V, Chapter 11, Sections 2 to 3
	Apr 1	General Equilibrium	S&V, Chapter 11, Section 4
	Market Failure: Imperfect Competition and Externalities		
	Apr 3	Apr 3: Problem set 6 due Monopoly Performance and Pricing	- S&V, Chapter 12, Sections 1 to 3 “FTC Chair Lina Khan on Antitrust in the Age of Amazon.” <i>Planet Money</i>, November 3, 2023. https://www.npr.org/transcripts/1197954506
12	Apr 7	Monopoly Performance and Pricing	S&V, Chapter 12, Section 4; Chapter 13, Section 4D
	Apr 8	No class (Extra office hours on Zoom)	
	Apr 10	Review for midterm exam 2	

Week		Topics	Required Reading
13	Apr 14	<i>Apr 14: Midterm exam 2 in class</i>	
	Apr 15	<i>No class (Ruhlman conference)</i>	
	Apr 17	Monopsony	S&V, Chapter 12, Section 5
14	Apr 21	Oligopoly Models	S&V, Chapter 14, pages 1 to 6; Section 3 (pages 10 to 16); page 19
	Apr 22	<i>No class</i>	
	Apr 24	<i>Apr 24: Problem set 7 due</i> Externalities	- S&V, Chapter 15, Sections 1 to 3 “Scarcity and Pistachios.” <i>Planet Money</i>, July 29, 2020. https://www.npr.org/transcripts/896308345
15	Apr 28	Catch-up and Review for final exam	
	Apr 29	Review for final exam	
16	May 5 to 8	<i>Final exam period</i>	

Brightspace Instructions for Submitting Problem Sets

- Please submit all problem sets via Brightspace. ***Do not email problem sets.***
- Please submit your problem set as ***a single PDF file.*** Do not upload multiple files and do not use other file formats as I may be unable to open other formats.
- Below are some methods for converting your files into a PDF file. Please let me know if you need any assistance with this.
 - If you have a Word document (or alternatively, if your problem sets are handwritten or in some other format, take images of the pages and paste them in one Word document), click File>Save as Adobe PDF.
 - If you have a Google document (or alternatively, if your problem sets are handwritten or in some other format, take images of the pages and paste them in one Google document), click File>Download>PDF Document.
 - Scan your problem set using Google Drive (<https://support.google.com/drive/answer/3145835?co=GENIE.Platform%3DAndroid&hl=en>) or the free Adobe Scan app from the Google Play Store, Apple App Store or Samsung Galaxy Store (<https://www.adobe.com/devnet-docs/adobescan/android/en/scan.html>) and save as a PDF.
- To submit your problem set:
 - Click “Assignments” in the top menu in Brightspace.
 - Click on the problem set and then click on “Add a File” in the middle of the page that opens and select your PDF file to upload.
 - Click “Add”.
 - Remember to click “Submit” after your problem set is attached.
 - ***You should see a “File submission successful” notification on the screen.*** Click “Done”. ***You should receive a “Submission receipt” email confirming that your problem set has been submitted.***